The Awakening of Modern Chinese Women from Cao Yu's Plays: Taking "Thunderstorm," "Sunrise," and "Beijing People" as Examples

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Abstract. This article takes Cao Y u's "Thunderstorm," "Sunrise," and "Beijing People" as the research object, focusing on the awakening of female characters in three plays as the theme. By analyzing the awakening performances of different types of women, such as rebels under feudal oppression (such as Fan Yi), confused individuals during social transformation (such as Chen Bailu), and awakened individuals in feudal society (such as Yuan Yuan), this study explores the narrative logic and cultural motivations behind their awakening, including the influence of ideological trends in their time, the design of dramatic conflicts, and the inheritance and innovation of literary traditions. At the same time, this article will also analyze the limitations of these women's awakenings, such as the disconnect between individual awakenings and social reality, the male perspective in gender narratives, and explore their implications for contemporary women's self-awareness awakening. The aim is to sort out the typicality of women's awakenings in Cao Y u's plays in contemporary literature, provide historical references for the research and development of contemporary women's consciousness, and summarize their literary value and historical significance.

Keywords: Cao Yu's Plays, Female Awakening, Thunderstorm, Sunrise, Beijingers

1 Introduction

In the brilliant galaxy of modern Chinese literature, Cao Yu's plays have become important texts for analyzing the spirit of the times with profound insights into human nature and exquisite textual expression. From the ethical and moral fission that erupted on the stormy night in "Thunderstorm", to the social problems reflected in the colorful society in "Sunrise", and to the collision of old and new ideas in the collapse of feudal families in "Beijing People", his writing always closely maintains a core proposition about the changes of the times - the awakening of people, and the spiritual awakening of women is the most touching chapter among them.

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The waves of the New Culture Movement and the May Fourth Movement broke through the barriers of feudal ethics, and "human liberation" became a topic that echoed throughout the times. As the most oppressed group from ancient times to the present, women's awakening is not only the sprouting of individual consciousness, but also an important manifestation of promoting the progress of the times. Cao Y u used drama as a mirror to depict the complex scene of female characters struggling to survive in the gap between tradition and modernity. These images not only carry the residual warmth of the May Fourth Movement's ideological liberation, but also reflect the pains of social transformation. The awakening of these female characters is a microcosm of the growth of modern Chinese women's consciousness.

However, existing research mostly focuses on the interpretation and exploration of a single image, and there is still room for expansion in the systematic review of the overall context, cultural motivations, and limitations of women's awakening in Cao Yu's dramas. Based on this, this article will take "Thunderstorm" "Sunrise", and "Beijing People" as the core, deeply analyze the awakening connotations and manifestations of different female images, explore the narrative logic and cultural motivations behind them, and critically examine the breakthroughs and limitations of this awakening in historical development. This not only helps to quickly clarify the narrative characteristics of women's awakening in modern Chinese literature, but also provides historical references for the development and construction of contemporary women' consciousness.

2 Main Body

This article will focus on three plays, "Thunderstorm," "Sunrise," and "Beijing People," andanalyze them in three parts: "Women's A wakening under the Decline of Feudal Families, "Women's Choices under the Collision of Old and New Ideas," and "The Significance and Limitations of Women's A wakening in the Era."

2.1 The A Wakening of Women under the Decline of Feudal Families

In the play 'Beijing People', the Zeng family is a typical representative of the decline of feudal families. This is a typical feudal literati family, once prominent for a time, but now in the transitional period between old and new society, they have become unable to make ends meet and their thinking has gradually become backward. Some people say, 'Peking Man' has occupied a place in revolutionary literature and art with its profound anti feudal theme, shining an indelible brilliance in the history of modern literature [1]. Comparing the work "Thunderstorm" from the same period, the Zeng family lived in a classical courtyard, while the Zhou Puyuan family lived in a Western style building with a private car. The Zeng family drinks ginseng soup; The Zhou family drinks soda. The young master of the Zeng family plays kites; The young master of the Zhou family plays tennis. The grandson of the Zeng family has to memorize ancient texts before going to bed every day, but Zhou Chong "gave him forty yuan" and asked him to buy books to read on his own. The old man of the Zeng fami-

ly is sick and refuses to hire a traditional Chinese medicine doctor to go to the hospital, while the Zhou family has a German doctor named Ke who works as a family health doctor. They even plan to sell their house to the church to become a hospital [2]. There are many comparisons like this, which can better reflect the decay and backwardness of the Zeng family. In such an environment, female characters are firmly bound by feudal ethics and endure enormous pain and pressure. As the representative of women in the new era in "Beijing People", Yuan Yuan's personal image forms a sharp contrast and strong contradiction with the feudal and rigid atmosphere of the Zeng family. This also reflects Cao Yu's independent thinking on the awakening of women in the context of the collision of old and new ideas.

The 'Free Man' Who Breaks Through the Shackles of Feudalism. Yuan Yuan is the daughter of anthropologist Y uan Rengan. She received Western ideological education from a young age and has a simple, lively, and unrestrained personality. She liveswith her father in the courtyard of the Zeng family. Despite the constraints and limitations on the living space of ancient Chinese women in the context of traditional feudal culture, Yuan Yuan disdains being bound by feudal rules and dares to publicly ridicule the conservatism of the elders of the Zeng family, even bringing her grandson Zeng Ting to raise pigeons and play around [3]. The character of "kill if you want, hit if you want" in Beijing is vividly reflected in Y uan Y uan. She plays with whoever she wants, ignores whoever she doesn't like, and smiles no matter what she says, without being constrained by power [4]. This so-called 'exceedance' is essentially a criticism of the constraints of feudal ethics on women, while also showcasing the unique personality of women in the new era who pursue freedom.

The 'Enlightener' of Spiritual Awakening. The existence of the character Yuan Yuan not only reflects the awakening of women in the new era, but also further promotes the awakening of Rui Zhen. As the granddaughter -in-law of the Zeng family, Ruizhen was originally restrained and obedient under the feudal arranged marriage. However, Yuan Yuan's carefree and free spirit, as well as her description of the "outside world," further awakened Ruizhen's deep desire for freedom. In the end, Ruizhen decided to break free from the shackles of marriage and leave the Zeng family with Yuan Yuan's family to go to the free outside world. Yuan Yuan's "enlightenment" towards Rui Zhen was not deliberate preaching, but rather influencing others with his own charm, which also confirms the subtle influence of ideological liberation in the new era on the awakening of feudal women.

The 'Ideal Epitome' Within the Limitations of the Times. Compared to Fan Yi's fierce resistance in "Thunderstorm" and Chen Bailu's confused sinking in "Sunrise", Yuan Yuan's image is more idealized: she has a good family background, and her father Yuan Rengan, as a new intellectual, deeply inspired her. Even though she did not directly bear the oppression of feudal marriage, her awakening is different from other characters and is less accompanied by painful struggles. But at the same time, this idealization also reflects the limitations of the times: in that era, there were very

few women who could have the freedom of choice and an open-minded family like Yuan Yuan, and most women still needed to survive in the gap between the old and new societies.

Although Yuan Yuan's role in the play "Beijing People" is not significant, she plays a "finishing touch" role. Her presence not only enriches the female characters in Cao Yu's works, but also reflects the need for women's awakening to break the oppression and constraints brought by the feudal environment and embrace a broader free world.

2.2 Women's Choices Under the Collision of Old and New Ideas

In the era of intense collision between old and new ideas, female characters in Cao Yu's works face more severe survival difficulties and value choices. Fan Yi in "Thunderstorm" and Chen Bailu in "Sunrise" respectively depict the struggle of modern women between traditional shackles and modern freedom in different postures. Their awakening journey is full of unknown tragedy and has become a typical epitome of the female spirit in the period of social transformation.

The 'Initial Awakening' in the Feudal Prison - Fan Yi's Rebellious Ideological Awakening. Fan Yi in "Thunderstorm" is a rebel who was oppressed to the extreme under the feudal family system. The shackles of feudal marriage and the oppression of the patriarchal system caused her great harm, and her abnormal love with her stepson Zhou Ping became one of her spiritual pillars in resisting feudal life - not just a simple emotional attachment, but also a silent rebellion against the shackles of feudal marriage.

Cao Yu's works are deeply influenced by the Yangtze River culture, and characters such as Fan Yi in his works showcase the pioneering and rebellious character traits of the Chu people, while also incorporating the pursuit of the poetic realm [5]. Her awakening was somewhat destructive: she dared to stage a "forbidden love" with her stepson in the feudal family, dared to publicly unveil the hypocritical veil of the Zhou family, and even tore apart all the hypocritical ethical disguises on the night of the thunderstorm. This kind of resistance is full of tragic colors, causing her spirit to be trapped in the feudal cage of the Zhou family, unable to break free from the constraints brought by her feudal identity, and unable to find a real way out, ultimately leading to destruction in the disintegration of the Zhou family. But it is precisely this spiritual struggle with blood and tears that has made her one of the most rebellious female characters in the history of modern and contemporary Chinese literature. The intensity of her awakening precisely confirms the deep persecution of people by feudal oppression.

The "Sinker" in the Drunken World - Chen Bailu's Confused Awakening. In "Sunrise", Chen Bailu is situated in an urban society where old and new ideas alternate. She was once a well-educated "Zhujun" with aspirations for love and freedom, but ultimately became a socialite in the ten-mile foreign market. Therefore, Chen

Bailu is compared to the "Camellia Girl" of China's semi-colonial period [6]. Her path of awakening is different from Fan Yi's fierce resistance, but gradually sinks in sobriety. She is acutely aware of her situation and current situation, but unable to break free. She once sympathized with the plight of the little thing and tried to lend a helping hand, which was her inner conscience that had not yet been extinguished, and her instinctive resistance to unfairness. But she had already become accustomed to relying on men to maintain a glamorous life, lost the ability to survive independently, and slowly fell into a clear and sinking state.

Chen Bailu's confusion is reflected in her conflicting understanding of "freedom". The "freedom" in her mouth is more about breaking free from the constraints of feudal ethics and enjoying the indulgence of material life, rather than true spiritual independence and personal freedom. She numbed herself in the bustling metropolis, and ultimately chose to commit suicide just as the sunrise was approaching, putting an extreme end to this wavering struggle betweenclarity and despair. Her awakening is a self perception with despair, revealing the true manifestation of some women losing themselves in material temptations and spiritual difficulties during the period of social transformation.

The Significance and Limitations of Women's Awakening in the Era. The awakening of women in Cao Y u's works is a microcosm of the transformation of women's consciousness from ignorance to self-awareness in modern Chinese society, providing certain reference value for the development of women in later generations. However, it has never completely surpassed the limitations of the era and gender perspective, triggering deep thinking in later generations.

2.3 The Significance of Women's Awakening in the Era

Women have always been in a state of dependence and speechlessness in the traditional ethical and moral context of China, and this oppressed situation is largely due to the limitations imposed on women in the "internal" field of the family [7]. In Cao Y u's plays, women challenge feudal ethics with a fierce attitude. Fan Yi tore apart the hypocritical mask of feudal marriage with her "forbidden love", She has "fiery enthusiasm and a strong heart. She dares to break through all shackles and fight for a trapped beast" [8].While Yuan Yuan broke through the fence of "feudal ethics" with her free nature. Their resistance was not only a personal liberation from oppression, but also reflected the oppression of women's spirit by feudal ethics. As researchers have pointed out, Cao Yu criticized feudal male dominated literature by depicting the "intense rebellion and spiritual breakthrough" of female characters.

At the same time, Cao Y u's plays also reflect a true reflection of women's survival difficulties. For example, as an urban woman during the transition from old to new society, Chen Bailu demonstrated a clear sense of decline in the city, revealing the unique predicament of women in the period of social transformation. Although she broke free from the constraints of feudal ethics, she also fell into a new predicament where capital and patriarchy intertwined. Her tragedy shattered the idealized imagina-

tion of women's liberation after the May Fourth Movement. Without the support of economic foundation and social system, the so-called "liberation" was just empty talk. This profound depiction of reality provides vivid references for understanding the real living conditions of women in the Republic of China. In short, Cao Y u's plays, like the literary practice of Enlightenment thought, provide reference significance for the development of modern women. For example, in "Beijing People," Yuan Yuan's "unconscious enlightenment" of Rui Zhen confirms the subtle influence of ideological liberation. She did not need to preach, but awakened the feudal women's longing for external freedom based solely on her innocent and naive nature. This precisely confirms that individual awakening does not exist in isolation, it can form a radiating ability, promote more women to break free from feudal shackles, and pass on female consciousness from generation to generation.

3 The Significance and Limitations of the Times of Female Awakening

The awakening of women in Cao Y u's works, although having a certain influence on the development of modern women, has never completely surpassed the limitations of the times and gender perspectives, and there are still certain limitations to the awakening of women. Firstly, there is a disconnect between individual awakening and social reality. Whether it's Fan Yi's destruction, Chen Bailu's suicide, or Yuan Yuan's forward thinking, they all point to a core issue: their awakening lacks systematic social support. Fan Yi's resistance remained at the level of emotional expression, in order to touch the foundation of feudal dregs: although Chen Bailu had already realized the absurdity of the feudal system, she was unable to survive alone; Yuan Yuan's "freedom" was built on the protection of her father's enlightenment, and it was difficult to become a replicable model for ordinary women in that society at that time. Such actions exposed the fatal weakness of women's liberation in the Republic of China - detachment from social revolution and institutional change, thus the awakening of individuals will eventually become a tragedy. The tragic fate of women themselves is closely related to their living space and the subordinate nature of their spiritual world. [9]" Secondly, there are limitations to the narrative of female awakening from a male perspective. As a male, Cao Y u's writing on the awakening of women has not completely escaped the traces the male perspective gaze. Fanyi's fierce resistance against the old society was labeled as "crazy", and the rationality of her awakening was described as being attached to Zhou Ping's emotions. Chen Bailu's "clear-headed sinking" was labeled as "red-faced and unlucky", weakening her criticism of the patriarchal society; Y uan Y uan's image is too idealized, essentially a male intellectual's idealized construction of "new era women". In these dramas, the awakening of women has never been able to break free from the constraints of male characters, reflecting the limitations of male writers' understanding of women's awakening consciousness during the Republican era, and the fact that women's independence has not yet been placed at the center of completely autonomous narrative.

Finally, the overly singular and idealized path of women's awakening during the Republican era was also one of the reasons why women's awakening had certain limitations. Fan Yi and Chen Bailu's ideological awakening and the disability of social reality Cool, which makes them struggle in pain all the time, which leads to their .The behavior is bound to break the routine and move towards the madness that people thought at that time [10]. The awakening of women in Cao Yu's works is often presented in extreme ways, such as destruction, suicide, and escape. Less likely to demonstrate the possibility of women achieving individual freedom through normal paths such as labor and study. Yuan Yuan's "freedom" relies on an open-minded family background, Chen Bailu's "clarity" is accompanied by the decline of self-awareness, and Fan Yi's "outburst" only exists on the emotional level. This awakening method is too intense and detached from social reality. Although it increases the tension and character contradictions of the drama itself, it also simplifies the diversity of women's liberation and to some extent shortens the imagination of women's consciousness growth.As scholar Tang Tianyue pointed out in "On the Spiritual Connotation of Female Images in Cao Yu's Dramas", Cao Yu, with his unique dramatic style, endowed these female characters with strong self-awareness and resistance spirit, becoming an important example of female awakening writing in modern Chinese literature. [9]"

4 Conclusion

The awakening of women in Cao Yu's works is diverse and reflects the twists and turns on the path of gender liberation. When Fan Yi burst into flames breaking through the feudal secular world in the thunderstorm of Zhou Mansion, when Chen Bailu soberly sank under the neon lights of social occasions, and when Yuan Yuan rushed to unknown distant places with the halo of idealism and freedom, these female images no longer represent personal destiny, but the vivid practice of human awakening in the gender dimension. This value lies in its tearing apart the moral standards of "Three Obediences and Four Virtues, liberating women from inherent labels, and restoring vibrant individuals with desires, thoughts, and a spirit of resistance. Fanyi's paranoid pursuit of "love and freedom" broke the shackles of feudal marriage on women; Chen Bailu maintained her original clarity in the midst of sinking, piercing through the illusory spiritual shell of feudal society; Yuan Yuan's free and innocent personality proves the truth that 'freedom is a human instinct'. They liberated themselves through struggle and shouting, pursued the awakening of women, and provided literary models and spiritual sparks for the women's liberation movement in later generations. The value of these women lies in their imperfections. Their struggles bear the imprint of the times, and their limitations reflect the shortcomings of the times. However, it is precisely this reality that allows their path of awakening to still have a profound impact on us a hundred years later. From them, we not only see the difficulties of women's awakening, but also understand the power of this awakening. This is never an isolated cry, but an epic written by generations of women with their lives, growing towards a freer future in the long river of history.

However, the limitations of history also follow closely. The awakening of these women has always lacked support: Fan Yi's awakening lacked institutional support and ultimately became a personal emotional release; Chen Bailu's awakening lacked an economic foundation and could only lead to destruction in the transition between old and new societies; Yuan Yuan's freedom and naivety were too idealistic, detached from the difficulties faced by the vast majority of women in society. Looking back at history from a contemporary perspective, Cao Y u's portrayal of women's awakening has a certain foresight. It reflects the complexity of gender liberation: true female independence is never a simple individual action, but requires the interaction of economic foundation and institutional construction.At the same time, it also enlightens contemporary women that the path of women's awakening requires individual courage and social progress to complement each other - it requires courage like Fan Yi, clarity like Che Bailu, and a longing for the unknown world like Yuan Yuan, as well as the popularization of education, economic independence, and institutional guarantees. Only when individuals and society work together can women's awakening and future development become better and better. From the resonant resistance in thunderstorms, the clear consciousness at sunrise, to the diverse choices of women in today's workplace, family, and society, more and more people are realizing the importance of women's awakening, and women's social status is gradually improving. The female characters in Cao Yu's works always remind us that awakening is not the end, but an eternal issue that all humanity must face. The exploration that was hindered by the constraints of the feudal system has long become the path under the feet of modern women; The institutional limitations that our predecessors failed to overcome are becoming the guiding light for us to continue moving forward. This may be the power of history, learning from history and creating the future. And literary works bring history into reality, turning past struggles into nourishment for the future. In the cycle of "breaking and standing", they push women step by step towards awakening, and those unattainable ideals are gradually brought into reality. Cao Yu's works continue to provide rich ideological resources for contemporary society to consider gender issues, inspiring people to constantly strive for gender equality.

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